Wayside School Gets a Little Stranger

By Louis Sachar

INTRODUCTION

All the kids from Wayside School had to spend 243 days in horrible schools while Wayside closed to get rid of the cows (Don't ask!). *Now the kids are back, but the big surprise is that their favorite and strangest teacher, Mrs. Jewls, is expecting a baby -- one named Cootie Face or Bucket Head--and a substitute teacher is coming . . .*

Now, having a substitute teacher can be great for many students. They either give you an easy assignment or let you watch a movie, but then there are the weird subs, who take their job way too seriously, or the downright evil subs who just don't like children at all. Wendy Norad, the final substitute for Ms. Jewls falls into the last category . . . and this is why!

The back-story of Ms. Norad from Wayside School Gets a Little Stranger by Louis Sachar.

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Wendy had three. Ears, I mean.

She had one ear on each side of her head, just like most people. But she also had a third ear, which lay flat on top of her head.

You couldn't see it. It was completely covered by her thick, frizzy brown hair.

She was an intelligent and lovely young woman. She was gentle and kind. At least, she used to be. Then she met Xavier and became evil and wicked, but I'll get to that later.

She lived in a small apartment in the big city. She always kept fresh flowers in the vase on her kitchen table. She didn't have any friends. She was afraid someone might find out about her ear. She was very embarrassed by it. The one on top of her head, I mean. The other two ears were pretty, as ears go. Actually, the third ear wasn't ugly. In fact, it looked just like the other two. It was quantity, not quality, that bothered her.

Then she met Xavier. It was at a museum. They happened to be standing next to each other looking at

the same painting. The *Mona Lisa*. A guard stood by to make sure they didn't touch it. Xavier was very handsome. But he was frightfully shy. He was afraid of women.

"That's a beautiful painting, isn't it?" said Wendy.

Xavier blushed. He wanted to speak, but his mouth locked shut with fear. It took all his courage just to nod his head. But Wendy knew he liked her. Because there was something else about her ear I haven't told you yet. The one on top of her head, I mean. It didn't hear normal sounds. It heard people's brains. Wendy was able to listen to Xavier's secret thoughts. And this is what she heard.

Yes, the painting is very beautiful. But you are more beautiful than the Mona Lisa. I wish somebody would paint your picture. I would buy it and look at it all day. Alas, if only I had the courage to talk to you.

Wendy didn't usually listen to other people's thoughts. She thought it was rude, even though the other people didn't know she was listening. Besides, most people's thoughts were usually boring. Xavier was getting

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too nervous standing next to her. He moved on to another painting. Wendy followed him. She listened to the lonely man's thoughts. They weren't boring at all. Most of his thoughts were about her, but she also learned a few other things. He liked to read his favorite author was Charles Dickens. He loved animals, especially dogs.

"That painting reminds me of a book," said Wendy. "*A tale of two cities*, by Charles Dickens. Have you read it?"

"Yes!" Xavier blurted, a little too loudly. "It's my favorite book! I've read everything Dickens has ever written. Twice. My favorite part is when-"He suddenly stopped, very embarrassed.

"Please go on," said Wendy.

"No, I don't want to bother you." said Xavier.

"You're not bothering me," said Wendy. "Charles Dickens is my favorite author. I sometimes read aloud to my dog."

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"You have a dog?" asked Xavier. Wendy nodded. Xavier stared into her dark eyes. "I love dogs." he said, as his brain said *I love you.*

Wendy and Xavier spent the afternoon together. He could hardly stop talking. It was like a genie had escaped from a bottle. All the love and emotion that had been buried for so long inside him came pouring out on Wendy. "I don't even know your name," he suddenly blurted.

"Wendy Nogard," said Wendy.

"I'm Xavier Dalton." said Xavier. They shook hands and made plans to meet again at the museum the following week.

On her way home, Wendy stopped by the library and checked out *a tale of two cities.* Then she went to the pet store and bought a dog.

A month later. Xavier asked her to marry him. Wendy didn't know what to say. She loved Xavier. And she knew he loved her. But she still hadn't told him about her ear. The one on top of her head, I mean. He knew about the other two. He had nibbled on each of them.

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"Marriage is a big step." she said. "I'm afraid we haven't known each other long enough.

"I've known you long enough to know I could never be happy without you." said Xavier. "Before I met you, Wendy, I was sad and lonely. But I was used to it. Now I can't imagine living like that again. I don't know what I'd do without you." He stroked her hair.

"Well, there's this one little thing you don't know about me," said Wendy. His hand bumped into it. "What's this thing?" he asked.

"That's what I was going to tell you about, dear." said Wendy. Xavier parted her hair and looked at it.

"It's an ear!" he exclaimed.

"Yes, it is." said Wendy. "Some people have two ears. I have three. Now that you know, if you still want to marry me, my answer is yes! Yes, sweetheart, yes!"

"I love you," said Xavier. "That's all that matters to me." That was what he said. But this is what he was thinking.

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Oh, gross! You're disgusting! I never want to touch you again! I can't even stand to look at you! You tricked me, you freak! You monster!

And of course, Wendy heard every word.

He stood up. "I'll be right back, sweetheart. I bought you diamond earrings as an engagement present. I just need to run back to the jewelry store and buy one more." He hurried out the door. She never saw him again.

I'm sorry to say this story has a sad ending. Xavier, thanks to Wendy, got over his shyness. He went out with lots of women but broke each one's heart. He could never love any of them. There was a hole in his heart. He was in love with Wendy Nogard, but he didn't know it. And so he could never be happy.

Wendy became a bitter and evil person. She was unhappy, and she wanted everyone else to be unhappy too. Whenever she heard someone thinking happy thoughts, she would listen closely and then do and say just the right thing to make the person feel rotten. She hated children the most.

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Every time she passed a playground, she heard them laughing and having fun. So she became a substitute teacher.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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